officials, or just anyone who was opposed to the CPI(ML). Mazumdar, who was in hiding in Kolkata, was the driving force behind the ‘left adventurist’ line, whereas Sanyal remained faithful to his followers in the rural areas of northern West Bengal and stayed there.

On 9 April 1970, Radio Beijing announced, ‘at present, the flames of peasants’ armed struggle have spread to West Bengal, Bihar, Uttar Pradesh, Punjab, Himachal, Orissa, Assam and Tripura, and particularly Andhra Pradesh’.[75] Later that year, the CPI (ML) sent Sourin Bose, a senior cadre, to Beijing where he held talks with Zhou Enlai and Kang Sheng. By that time, Chinese enthusiasm for the Indian revolutionaries was beginning to wane. Kang Sheng reportedly told Bose that the CCP could not understand the meaning of the ‘Naxalite’ concept of ‘annihilation’, which he likened to the methods used in China by ‘left adventurists’ after the defeat of the Communists there in 1927. Mazumdar had also coined a phrase which Zhou criticized: *Chiner Chairman Aamader Chairman* (China’s Chairman is Our Chairman).[76]

The Naxalites, as the Indian Maoists came to be known after the village where the 1967 rebellion occurred, were too radical even for the rabid ideologue and diehard Mao-supporter, Kang. Zhou told Bose that, ‘we don’t deny that Chairman [Mao] is [an] international authority…[but] to regard a leader of one country as the leader of another party is against the sentiment of the nation; it is difficult for the working class to accept it.’[77]

Bose flew back to Kolkata via London, bringing with him the depressing news from Beijing. At a meeting in Kolkata on 8 December 1970, the leaders of the CPI(ML) agreed not to disclose to their followers that the Chinese were critical of their polices, and that the party would get no support, moral, material, or otherwise, from China.[78]

It is quite possible that the Naxalites could have developed their movement into a more powerful force if Sanyal had managed to control it, and then Chinese aid would also most probably have been forthcoming. But before long, factionalism tore their tiny groups apart and the Chinese decided to disregard them when it became clear that they were not going to become a viable force in Indian politics.

On 16 July 1972, Mazumdar was betrayed by one of his comrades and captured at his hideout in Kolkata. Twelve days later, he died in police custody. No Chinese aid ever reached the CPI (ML). Instead, the Chinese